

Moodle

Helps a Business School Overcome Administrative Challenges



Over the past several years, the Inmantec Business School, Ghaziabad, faced problems related to information flow from departments to students, faculty members, department staff members, and between departments. This often led to chaotic situations. Till, one day, Moodle was discovered! Here's a first hand account of how Moodle helped the school overcome a number of administrative challenges.

Initially, we used to do everything on paper. To send some information to our students, we would put up a notice on our college notice board; for faculty members, we sent paper circulars and notices to each faculty member (sending a peon to all faculty members' desks for their signature). The same process was used for other departmental staff. In the case of faculty members, the peon often returned saying that those whom the circular was addressed to, were not at their desks.

As the head of a department, I personally faced issues communicating with students. We had to pass on information during classes, or paste notices on the notice boards. However, students often don't bother to check notice boards. When asked, they usually say: "We haven't read it." Some students will even tell you that the "notice was not on the notice board." We tried displaying notices on our website, but the volume of notices was so high that the website was unable to handle this. Another issue was that we had to ask the website admin to upload the notices!

Next, we tried sending information via email. Each member of the faculty and staff was given an email account for communications from the department to students, faculty members and staff. There were problems with this too: people reported that they hadn't received the mail, or that mails were being marked as spam (we used to send mails to over 100 students and faculty members at one time). In fact, our domain was getting blacklisted at the server level. Also, to send mails to students, we had to personally ask for their email IDs. Moreover, we found that some students constantly changed their email IDs as they forgot their account passwords—and they rarely bothered to give us the new address!

We humans tend to forget things. It often happened that I would overlook some students and faculty members

in the recipient list, resulting in the information not being sent to them. It's my responsibility to pass on the information, but that was not always fulfilled.

Viruses! Worms! Trojans!

Now let's look at the issues faced by our academic departments. Most of our academic departments faced issues with transferring lecture notes/handouts and presentations, movies or multimedia files; or when sending urgent notices to students that needed immediate attention. For these, we used pen drives, and personally transferred the contents to student laptops. Naturally, this gave rise to another problem. A virus on one system would infect the pen drive, which, when plugged in to other systems, would infect them all. Viruses spread from teachers' computers to students', and vice-versa. Viruses also spread through our campus Wi-Fi network, to connected systems. Transferring data through pen drives infected our entire network and systems, hampering everybody's performance. This created an urgent need to procure antivirus software for our networks, personal computers and laptops.

Then, to decrease the use of pen drives, which were a huge infection vector, we began using email to distribute our educational material. This resulted in over-consumption of Internet bandwidth, since transmission from our email accounts, and receipt/downloading by students would be in the course of the same day.

To find a solution, we tried different management systems, and even developed our own management system called 'Online Academic Zone', plus a website with space to upload all the information pertaining to our departments and staff. There were several issues that cropped up while developing the software (some of which I will discuss in the following sections). There were also problems related to maintaining the website.